

The Application File

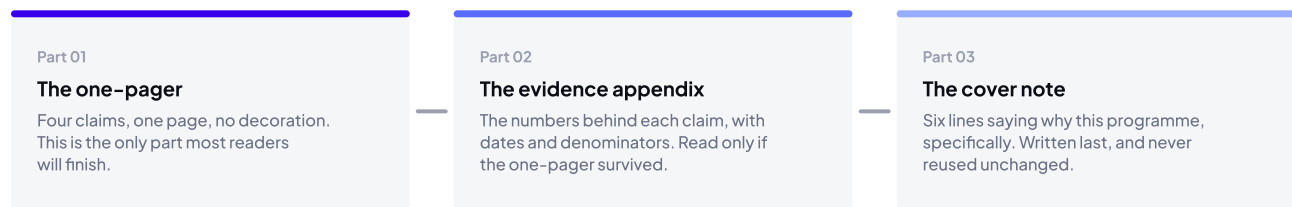
Apply with a file, not a hope. Everything a reviewer needs, assembled so it works without you in the room — which is exactly how it will be read.



Your file is read for ninety seconds, by somebody tired.

A reviewer working through a hundred applications is not looking for reasons to say yes. They are looking for reasons to stop reading, because stopping is how the pile gets smaller. Everything below is built around that fact rather than around what would be pleasant to believe.

This has a practical consequence that most applicants miss: the file is not a persuasion document. It is a verification document. Your job is to make four claims and make each one instantly checkable. Persuasion happens later, in a room, if the file has done its job.



Three parts, read in this order and usually not all of them. Build them in reverse: the evidence first, then the page it supports, then the note that points at it.

Four claims, in the order they are checked

The structure below is not a style preference. It follows the order a reviewer's questions arrive in, which means each section answers the question the previous one just raised. Reordering it makes the reader hold questions open, and a tired reader with open questions stops.

SECTION	WHAT IT SAYS	LENGTH
The problem	One named person, one situation, what it costs them.	Two lines
The evidence	How many people, how you know, and one quote.	Three lines
What exists	What you have built or run, and who has used it.	Two lines
Why you	The access, skill or history that is hard to copy.	Two lines
The ask	What you want from this programme specifically.	One line

The thing to delete first

The paragraph about how large the market is. A reviewer already knows the market is large — that is why they run the programme. It is the only section of an application that is identical across every applicant, so it carries no information about you at all.

Worksheet 1 · The one-pager

DRAFT IT HERE FIRST

Write it by hand before you type it. The constraint of the ruled lines does most of the editing for you.

The problem — named person, situation, cost

The evidence — number, how, and one verbatim quote

Fractions with denominators. "11 of 34", not "many".

What exists — what you built or ran, and who used it

Why you — the part that is hard to copy

The ask — from this programme, specifically

Every claim, with the number that supports it

The appendix exists so that a reviewer who wants to check one thing can find it in ten seconds. It is not a longer version of the one-pager and it should contain almost no prose. One row per claim, each with a date, a number and a source a person could follow up.

CLAIM ON THE ONE-PAGER	THE NUMBER	WHERE IT CAME FROM	DATE
People have this problem	17 of 20 raised it unprompted	Evidence log, Toolkit 02	March
It costs them real money	Median 4 hours a week, as stated	Evidence log, column 7	March
Something exists	10 deliveries, by hand	Delivery log, Toolkit 03	April
People want it enough to pay	11 of 34 paid a deposit	Test worksheet, Toolkit 04	May
They come back	6 of 10 returned with no reminder	Delivery log, weeks 4–6	May

Rows like these are what a reviewer means when they ask how you know. Note what they are made of: counts, denominators and dates, all of which came out of work you did anyway if you have used the earlier toolkits in this library. The appendix is an assembly job, not a writing job.

☐ **Every number has a denominator**

“30 sign-ups” becomes “30 of 210”, or it comes out.

☐ **Every claim has a date**

A reviewer discounts undated evidence to zero, and is right to.

☐ **Every row names a source somebody could check**

A log, a receipt, a person who agreed to be contacted.

☐ **Nothing appears here that is not on the one-pager**

The appendix supports claims; it does not add new ones.

☐ **No adjectives**

Strong, significant, huge, validated. Delete each one and see if the row still says anything.

☐ **It fits on one page**

If it does not, you are explaining rather than evidencing.

Six lines that could not have been sent to anyone else

The cover note is the only part of the file that is specific to the reader, and it is the part most applicants reuse unchanged. A note that names the programme's actual focus, one thing they have backed before, and what you want from them specifically is rare enough to be worth the twenty minutes it takes.

Worksheet 2 · The cover note

ONE PER PROGRAMME

Why this programme — something true about them, not about you

If the sentence would work for three other programmes, it is not this line.

The single strongest number from your appendix

What you want from them that is not money

Access, a specific mentor, a customer introduction, a licence question answered.

What you will have done by the time they decide

Shows the work continues whether or not they say yes. It nearly always helps.

SAY

NEVER SAY

11 of 34 paid a 50 EGP deposit in April.

We have strong early traction.

Six of ten came back with no reminder.

Users love the product.

I ran it by hand for ten people in Shubra.

We have built an MVP.

I want an introduction to two pharmacy chains.

We are seeking funding to scale.

The checks that catch most rejections

☐ **Someone who has never heard of you read the one-pager and explained it back correctly**

If they got the problem wrong, the file failed, not the reader.

☐ **Every number on the page also appears in the appendix, identically**

A mismatch between the two is the fastest way to lose a reviewer's trust.

☐ **The file opens without you**

No password, no request-access link, no format nobody has. A PDF.

☐ **Your name and a way to reach you are on page one**

This is missed more often than it sounds.

☐ **You have answered the actual questions asked**

Programmes ask specific things. Answering a different question reads as a mass send.

☐ **The strongest evidence is in the first five lines**

The reader may not reach line six.

☐ **You could defend every claim in a room, from the appendix alone**

If you cannot, remove the claim rather than soften it.

If you are not ready, send it anyway — to one place

A rejection with a reason is worth a month of guessing. Apply to one programme you expect to be declined by, ask for the reason, and treat the answer as the next month's brief. Apply to ten at once and you learn nothing ten times.

MISSION 01



MISSION 15

15

Where this sits. Mission 15. The file assembles from the logs and worksheets produced in missions 02, 03, 09, 13 and 14 — which is why it takes a weekend rather than a month.

Keep the file in one folder with the logs it cites. When somebody asks how you know, the answer should be a file you can send in under a minute, not a conversation you have to schedule.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH **Where you actually stand**

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS **Fifteen structured missions**

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF **A verifiable credential**

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

startpad.me

Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.